

Mr. Klein was so serious about the responsibilities of investing that I began to think he was a recruiter for the Peace Corps. Right away, he discouraged me from buying individual stocks and handed me two or three thick brochures that described his favorite products. One was a real estate limited partnership in which I'd be part owner of the Carlyle, a famous New York hotel whose rooms I could never afford. Mr. Klein read aloud from the list of the general partners, and it sounded like I'd be involved with some impressive co-owners. As flattered as I was, I wondered why these people would want to cut me in on their great deal.

There seemed to be a style of broker to suit every kind of client—lawyerly brokers for lawyers, snobbish brokers for snobs, bon-vivant brokers for bon vivants, gambler brokers for gamblers. There are brokers who talk like cab drivers and brokers who talk like college deans, brokers who dress like Mafiosi and brokers who dress like fashion models, brokers to mimic the appearance, speech, or personality of any conceivable customer, the mirror image of every station in life.

I began to wonder if it was better to choose a broker whose clothing matched mine, or one with whom I clashed. I would have preferred to choose a broker on more serious grounds, such as investment philosophy, but that seemed impossible. All the brokers I'd met were able to change attitudes, and even to switch basic investment philosophies, during the short space of an interview. I'd first seen this in Mr. Nemerov, who'd gone from the solid foundation of Treasury bills to selling me options in less than a half hour. A similar turnabout occurred at a second Merrill Lynch office, where I'd headed after leaving Mr. Klein.

This Merrill Lynch office was surrounded by angry stewardesses, protesting some sort of banking arrangement between Merrill Lynch and Eastern Airlines. I snuck my way past the picket signs, thinking that this was a good example of the trouble that results when brokerage firms get into banking.

Once safely inside the building, I approached the front desk and asked for the broker of the day. A man loitering at the entrance overheard me, handed me his card, and volunteered his services. His name was Michael Todd, but he said to call him "Mickey."

As we headed toward Mickey's cubicle, I told him I was a very